

Prospectus: Scaling Doomer Optimism

Building Equitable, Human-Scale Resilience in the Age of the Machine

May 2026

Submitted by: Ashley Fitzgerald (Colby), Co-Founder and Host, Doomer Optimism Podcast & Rizoma Field School

Executive Summary

Doomer Optimism has become one of the pre-eminent platforms for confronting the central question of our time: How do we live well in the age of the Machine? The interlocking forces of corporate consolidation, technological acceleration, ecological unraveling, and social alienation that erode autonomy, community bonds, dignified work, and planetary health.

The podcast (300+ episodes since 2021) rejects both techno-utopian denial and mainstream environmental despair. Instead, it platforms practitioners and thinkers who combine unflinching realism about systemic fragility with practical, community-led paths forward grounded in the wisdom of Wendell Berry, Ivan Illich, Christopher Lasch, and Morris Berman.

The Challenge

The dominant model of industrial agriculture, global supply chains, and concentrated corporate/political power is structurally fragile. It depends on cheap energy, stable climates, uninterrupted logistics, and ongoing consolidation over land, seeds, processing, and markets. These foundations are already cracking under climate extremes, resource limits, geopolitical instability, soil degradation, job loss in manufacturing, and deepening social distrust.

Corporate consolidation drives inequality, environmental degradation, and alienation. Technological acceleration (AI, automation, surveillance) further erodes worker autonomy, family resilience, and human-scale community. Mainstream institutions remain trapped in short-term reform, assuming the current architecture will persist. Doomer Optimism fills this gap: we combine rigorous analysis of long-term civilizational dynamics with the lived experience of practitioners who are actually building alternatives.

We draw inspiration from the historic labor cry of “bread and roses”: material sufficiency and beauty, dignity, creativity, and rooted belonging.

Content Focus: Arenas for Living Well in the Age of the Machine

Our episodes and companion articles explore practical, justice-oriented wisdom across key domains.

1. Regenerative Agriculture

Rebuilding soil, local food systems, and agrarian communities as foundations for food sovereignty and rural economic justice amid industrial consolidation.

Leading voice/host: Peter Allen (keystone-species restoration and hands-on agroecosystem design).

2. Conservation and Environment

Land stewardship, biodiversity, and environmental justice countering extractive systems through grounded, community-based models of conservation and ecological restoration.

Leading voice/host: James Pogue (reporting on land use conflicts, deglobalization, and the human dimensions of ecological upheaval).

3. The Built Environment (Urbanism, Sustainable & Traditional Construction)

Humane, human-scale settlements and traditional building techniques that resist soulless sprawl and promote equitable placemaking, beauty, and community durability.

Leading voices: Patrick Lemmon (Orthodox Masonry – traditional construction) and Chuck Marohn (Strong Towns – incremental, people-centered urbanism).

4. Technology, AI, and Transhumanism

Critiquing surveillance capitalism, automation's impact on labor, and transhumanist erosion of embodied life advocating convivial, democratic, and human-centered technology.

Key voice: Joe Allen (analysis of transhumanist trends and cultural/spiritual costs).

5. Right to Repair, Automation, and Surveillance

Defending worker autonomy, repairability, and freedom against corporate planned obsolescence and algorithmic control advancing technological democracy and labor justice.

Key voice: Gord Magill (right-to-repair and anti-surveillance advocacy).

6. Tech-Limited Child Rearing and Schooling

Exploring approaches to child rearing and education that limit screen-based technology, prioritize embodied learning, family and community formation, and reconnection to

land, craft, and place countering the commodification and alienation of digital childhood.

Leading host: Ashley Fitzgerald (scholarly and practical grounding in these domains).

Leadership, Partnerships, and Credibility

Doomer Optimism benefits from deep affiliations with highly respected voices who lend institutional credibility and cross-platform reach. James Pogue, a contributing writer for *The New York Times Opinion*, *Vanity Fair*, and *Harper's*, anchors our work on conservation, environment, and geopolitics. Other key affiliated voices include ecologist and farm-school founder Peter Allen, technology critic Joe Allen, and right-to-repair advocate Gord Magill.

The podcast and our events have hosted or featured a sitting member of Congress (Rep. Marie Gluesenkamp Perez), *New York Times* bestselling author Tucker Max, and *New York Times* bestselling author Paul Kingsnorth (who has spoken at multiple Doomer Optimism events and retreats). Several past guests and event participants have also appeared on major platforms, including *the Ezra Klein Show* (Santi Ruiz and James Pogue), *Tucker Carlson* (Gord Magill and Jeremy Carl), and Ross Douthat's *Interesting Times* (Jeremy Carl), which demonstrates our ability to be cutting edge and relevant across the ideological spectrum.

We have also received prominent press coverage, including a major profile in *The Free Press* ("The People Who Rage Against the Machine" by Suzy Weiss), which highlighted our pluralistic coalition of practitioners building meaning amid modernity's decline.

Searchable Research Library

A dedicated, publicly accessible section on the Doomer Optimism website will serve as a living, categorized knowledge hub. It will systematically compile and tag bibliographies, key resources, studies, and practical guides referenced across all episodes. Organized by content pillars (regenerative agriculture, conservation, technology critique, etc.), this library will transform ephemeral podcast discussions into a permanent, searchable archive for researchers, practitioners, educators, and community organizers.

Annual Events

We will host 1–2 high-impact events per year (in-person with video releases) that convene leading voices from the podcast and broader network. These gatherings will feature panels, workshops, and practical sessions focused on the question "how to live well in the age of the Machine," fostering deeper cross-pollination, skill-sharing, and community building.

Future Vision

In future years, our goal is to develop a more formal think tank arm, with detailed plans forthcoming. The podcast will serve as the incubator and network builder for potential fellows in the think tank who can develop white papers and policy briefs.

Expected Outcomes and Why Fund Now

This support will expand our reach, deepen our written archive, equitably compensate contributors, and catalyze measurable impact: strengthened farms and communities, policy influence, educational programs, events, and a lasting research library that equips people for just transitions.

In this moment of polycrisis, we have a unique opportunity to back platforms that counter corporate extraction, advance environmental and social justice, and cultivate community sovereignty and human flourishing. Doomer Optimism offers grounded, pluralistic hope through practical and rooted real people doing the work.

Thank you for considering this partnership in building shared prosperity and human-scale alternatives.

Sincerely,
Ashley Fitzgerald
Co-Founder & Host, Doomer Optimism